



Belgium



Belgium lies in northwestern Europe. Its history has been marked by tensions between the majority Dutch-speaking (Flemish) and minority French-speaking (Walloon) communities.



GEOGRAPHY

Low-lying coastal plain covers two-thirds of the country. Land becomes hilly and forested in the southeast (Ardennes) region.



CLIMATE

Maritime climate with Gulf Stream influences. Temperatures are mild, with heavy cloud cover and rain. More rainfall and weather fluctuations at the coast.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Since 1970, Flemish regions have become more prosperous than those of the minority Walloons, overturning traditional roles and increasing friction. Belgium moved to a federal system from 1980 in order to contain tensions, but recent fractious politics have raised doubts over the union's survival. Brussels hosts key European Union institutions.



THE ECONOMY

Variety of industrial exports, including steel, glassware, cut diamonds, and textiles. Very high levels of public debt. Bureaucracy larger than European average.



INSIGHT: *The Ardennes region, in the southeast of the country, is famous for its forests, lakes, and cuisine*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Kingdom of Belgium

DATE OF FORMATION: 1830

CAPITAL: Brussels

POPULATION: 10.6 million

TOTAL AREA: 11,780 sq. miles
(30,510 sq. km)

DENSITY: 840 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Dutch*, French*, German*

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 88%, other 10%, Muslim 2%

ETHNIC MIX: Flemish 58%, Walloon 33%, other 6%, Italian 2%, Moroccan 1%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Euro = 100 cents